relatively immature physically, I was determined to make an immediate impact in first-team cricket.

Not so quickly, young sir. Jeremy Farrell took me aside before the first game of the season and explained he had instead picked a sixth-former named James De Groot, who ironically, I now see regularly in his role as MCC's Head of Catering. I was told to go out and score runs for the Under-14s; I did so, making 80-odd not out as we chased down 140 against Haileybury, but my name still wasn't on the board announcing the team to play MCC the following Tuesday.

I was drifting in double physics, gazing out of the window on to the playing field, where the first team was warming up, when Mr Farrell interrupted the lesson. MCC were one short, and he wondered whether I fancied filling in. I didn't give him time to reconsider. It normally took seven minutes to walk to my boarding house; I reckon I did it there and back in six.

More lessons for later: in sport the biggest opportunities have a habit of presenting themselves when you least expect them. Be ready for anything. Make the moment matter. The MCC captain said I'd be batting at three; I'd barely got my pads on before I was walking to the wicket. Someone blurted out 'send him back to primary school' and I was greeted with a couple of bouncers.

Cricket, like other sports, is a state of mind. I could sense the tide turning in my favour as my score increased and the fielding team became more subdued. I reached my century with a shot that is daunting even for a senior pro, running down the wicket to clip the ball over midwicket, against the turn of an off-spinner. The match petered out into a draw, with the school eight wickets down in reply, but I felt like a winner as Mr Farrell shook my hand.

I was an honorary adult for the day and allowed to enjoy the rituals of men's cricket. I sat in the away changing room, drinking beer and listening to the stories become more improbable, before they drifted off. I returned to the boarding house around 9 p.m., gabbled my story to my parents and woke the next morning as a new man.

Suddenly, I was a name around school. I was still a little kid, but by the following Saturday my name was on the first-team message board. I read it several times, to make sure it was real. Word was getting round that I was a half decent player, and when I played for Essex seconds at Dunstable at the